



COMPREHENSIVE PROFILE · PATHWAY 1 OF 2

A complete picture of Riley M.

A whole-child action plan built directly from the answers you shared.
Designed to be read alone, with your care team, or alongside an IEP
conversation.

PREPARED FOR
Riley M., age 12

PROFILE BUILT BY
Maria (Mother)

REPORT DATE
April 30, 2026

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SECTION 01 · EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Whole Picture

How to use this report

Read sections 1–3 first. Section 4 (Communication) is the section to copy and hand to anyone new. The Reference Guide near the end is the single page you can print and post on the fridge or hand to a babysitter. The Appendix is a verbatim copy of every answer you shared, formatted to be handed to a new doctor, therapist, or the IEP team so Riley's story doesn't have to be told from scratch every time.

Riley is a 12-year-old autistic, PTSD-affected, synesthetic boy who is curious, exceptionally well-remembered, and powerfully connected to music, animals, books, and the right people. The current pressure point is the **collision between his rigid black-and-white thinking and his social anxiety**: his thought patterns pull him toward 'trick questions' and categorical judgments (red = bad, green = good, objects have feelings), which can antagonize the very people whose approval he then anxiously seeks. Layered on this is real PTSD from public-school years, sleep regression with new night fears, and the early storm of puberty — including emotional intensity that can produce involuntary physiological responses he doesn't yet have language for. The good news is real: his recovery time is *shortening*, his self-regulation toolbox is growing (the new rhythmic breathing sound is a wholly self-generated regulation attempt and a milestone), homeschool has restored him in ways public school could not, and he has a small handful of trusted adults whose presence reliably calms him. This report focuses on softening the rigidity loop without confronting it directly, supporting his social re-entry through low-stakes interest-anchored encounters, and equipping every adult around him with the same calm, predictable, low-emotion tone his nervous system needs in order to trust again.

Three anchor truths to start with

● Strengths first Riley's curiosity, memory, and love of music, animals, and books are the operating system. Every strategy in this report builds on those — never around them.	● Calm tone before words Riley's nervous system locks onto the adult's emotional state before the content lands. If you are frustrated, he won't hear the sentence — he'll only see your face. Regulate yourself first.	● Honor the lean Riley rarely greets new adults warmly. He WILL test the situation with elevated behaviors. If he gives a lean, comes close, or makes any move toward you — he is starting to trust. That is the win.
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SAMPLE
PIECES OF PERCEPTION · SAMPLE REPORT

SECTION 02 · QUICK REFERENCE

Riley at a Glance

A 1-page card. Print it, post it on the fridge, hand it to anyone new — babysitter, sub provider, ER triage nurse — who will be with Riley for an hour or a day.

WHO HE IS	Riley, 12, he/him. Autistic, with PTSD from public school, and synesthesia (he experiences objects, colors, and words as having feelings). Verbal — but uses 'trick questions' and may say things he knows are inappropriate when overwhelmed. Loves books, fonts, trains, music, his cats Pepper and Olive, and making people proud.
WHAT REGULATES HIM	Hugs — he asks for them many times a day, even when not visibly upset; honor every request. Books. Music of all kinds. Lyric-free music in the car is regulating. Walks. Car rides. The Heart Coherence app on his phone. An adult getting down to his eye level.
WHAT OVERWHELMS HIM	The energetic complexity of crowded spaces (NOT volume — energy: loud music in the car is fine, a busy room is not). Strong smells (the burnt-toast smell of breakfast diners). Stuck thoughts that compare two unrelated things. Frustrated or angry adult expressions. The word "STOP." Color-as-moral framing ("red is bad, green is good").
EARLY WARNING SIGNS	Verbal stimming and looping phrases. The new rhythmic breathing sound (this is a self-regulation attempt — a milestone — let it happen). Saying things he knows are inappropriate to confirm his "in trouble" perception. Asking trick questions to people he doesn't know well.
WHAT TO SAY	"I'm not going to feed that thought or worry." "I see you." "Let's take a deep breath together." Get down at his eye level. Offer a hug. Use one short sentence and stop.
WHAT NEVER TO SAY	"STOP." (Use pause / wait / hold on / freeze / hands down.) "Because I said so." Anything in a scolding tone. Color-as-moral framing — never tell him a color is "bad." Avoid showing visible frustration; he won't hear the words past your face.

IF HE MELTS DOWN	Lower your voice. Get close — at his eye level. Offer a hug; he may take it. Quiet space. Bath. Book time. Reduce all demands. Recovery is 30 min – a few hours; he is "bouncing back" faster than he used to. Affirm that out loud when he comes back.
FAVORITE THINGS	Books. Fonts (yes, the typography). Trains. Days of the week and years. His cats Pepper and Olive. Painting. Music — every kind. Animals. Outdoor walks. Lunch at exactly 12:00.
DO NOT	Use "STOP." Use color-as-moral. Show frustration or anger — he locks onto your face and forgets why. Push hard for engagement on a first encounter; let him give you the lean. Force eye contact.

SECTION 03 · SENSORY PROFILE

How Riley's Body Reads the World

Built from the sensory areas you flagged in the questionnaire. **Avoiding** means the input overwhelms — reduce it. **Seeking** means the input regulates — make it available. **Neutral** means it's not a problem — don't accommodate what isn't a problem.

Auditory · Energetic complexity

AVOIDING — High (specific to crowds, NOT volume)

WHAT WE SEE

Riley can listen to loud music in the car without issue, but a busy room overwhelms him. It's not the decibels — it's the complexity and energetic field of multiple voices, conversations, and movement happening at once.

WHAT TO DO

Pre-warn before entering a busy space. Have headphones available. Identify and step toward a quieter corner on arrival. Plan for a shorter visit and an exit route. Loud-music-in-the-car works as a transition tool — not a trigger.

Olfactory · Smell

AVOIDING — Moderate

WHAT WE SEE

Riley has a sensitive nose. Strong cooking smells — the burnt-toast / browned-grease smell of breakfast diners — are hard.

WHAT TO DO

Avoid diners or call ahead. If it's unavoidable, sit by a window or door, eat outside if possible, and have an exit ready.

Tactile · Hugs are gold

SEEKING — High (deep pressure)

WHAT WE SEE

Riley asks for hugs many times a day, even when he isn't visibly upset. Hugs ARE a primary regulator for him.

WHAT TO DO

Honor every hug request — every single one. Do not make him earn them. Offer them proactively when transitions are hard. Long, firm hugs > quick, light ones.

Proprioceptive · Movement & pressure

SEEKING — Moderate

WHAT WE SEE

Walks regulate him. Car rides regulate him. Karate — for his sister Sam — is a reliable shape of his afternoon.

WHAT TO DO

Build a daily walk into the rhythm. Don't wait for a hard moment to suggest movement; preempt with one.

Visual

Mostly Neutral

WHAT WE SEE

Not flagged in the questionnaire. Riley may have visual preferences related to fonts and aesthetics (one of his special interests) — that's an interest, not a sensitivity.

WHAT TO DO

Don't accommodate what isn't a problem. Lean into his font love as a connection point — show him a new typography book.

Vestibular · Movement / spinning

Mostly Neutral

WHAT WE SEE

Not flagged.

WHAT TO DO

Standard activity is fine; he doesn't appear to seek or avoid spinning, swinging, or balance-challenging activities.

Interoceptive · Body awareness

MIXED — needs grounding
to present moment

WHAT WE SEE

Riley describes his mind as "10 movies playing all at once." Mom regularly has to bring him back to present-moment awareness. This is interoceptive disconnect — a real and named experience.

WHAT TO DO

Grounding techniques: Heart Coherence app. Eye-level proximity. Naming what's happening ("You're here, with me, on the couch, and the cats are nearby"). Hugs anchor the body.

HOME & FAMILY CONTEXT

Where Riley Lives, and With Whom

Built directly from your answers about household structure. This section sits alongside every other section because transitions, household differences, and the people who move in and out of Riley's daily life are regulation factors — not background.

HOUSEHOLD COMPOSITION

Number of homes	2 homes
Primary household	Sarah (Mom) — Mother / primary parent / primary regulator Sam — Sister, age 14 — older sibling, shares both homes Pepper + Olive — Cats — emotional anchors, both at Mom's
Second household	Anthony (Dad) — Father / co-parent Sam — Sister, 14 — also moves between both
Co-parenting style	Mostly aligned, with some friction. Co-parents in different homes, language and approach largely consistent but not identical.
Transition cadence	A few days per week — Riley rotates between Mom's primary home and Dad's home.

TRANSITIONS BETWEEN HOMES

Difficulty: Some difficulty, varies by direction. Riley currently has more anxiety at Dad's — specifically reports being scared at night there but doesn't go in with Dad. At Mom's, he comes in to her at night.

What we observe: On hard transition days he loops more on stuck thoughts. Sleep is harder the first night back at either house. Comes back to baseline within 24-48 hours. The new self-regulation breathing sound shows up more on transition days — a healthy response.

Supports that already help: Books travel between homes. Cats Pepper and Olive stay at Mom's — this is part of why Mom's reads as primary regulator. Music plays in the car on every transition. A predictable 5-minute landing routine on arrival at either home would strengthen this further.

Differences between the homes that affect regulation

Mom's: cats present, salt lamp on at bedtime, more structured routine, books visible everywhere, Mom is the primary co-regulator (Riley comes in at night when scared). Dad's: no cats, Riley doesn't go in to Dad at night even when scared, different sensory environment. Both homes use the family language reset ("I'm not feeding that thought or worry," no STOP, no color-as-moral).

OTHER ADULTS IN RILEY'S WEEK

- **Emily** — Babysitter at Mom's — twice weekly
- **Gianna** — Babysitter at Mom's — twice weekly
- **Brooke** — Provider at the Autism Project (Mon + Thu)
- **Ms. Denise** — Speaking of Social (every other Tuesday)
- **Mr. Pezzillo** — Karate instructor (Fridays)
- **Declan + Emily** — Special Olympics coaches
- **Erika Doherty** — Backup family member
- **Emily (neighbor)** — Emergency local contact

SECTION 04 · STRENGTHS SPOTLIGHT

What Riley Does Beautifully

Anchored in the strengths you named. Every other section of this report builds on top of what's here — because regulation and growth grounded in identified strengths sticks.

● Cinematic memory Riley's recall is exceptional. He remembers facts, images, patterns, and details most adults forget. Use his memory as an on-ramp to anything new — he learns through facts.	● Music — every kind Music regulates and motivates. Loud in the car. Quiet when reading. Lyric-free or with lyrics — both work. This is the single most reliable regulation tool he has.
● Animal love Animals are emotionally safe. His cats Pepper and Olive are co-regulators in their own right. Animal-themed books, shows, and outings are reliable wins.	● Painting A regulating activity AND a creative output. Quiet, focused, tactile. A drawing pad is a meltdown-proof tool to keep nearby.
● Wants to make people proud Riley wants to be seen doing well. Visible, specific praise lands deeply: "You did your work today. That was hard, and you did it." Vague praise ("good job!") doesn't register the same way.	● Self-regulating breathing sound He has recently invented a rhythmic breathing sound that he uses to calm himself. This is HIS tool, not anyone else's. Don't comment on it. Don't try to teach him a different one. Let him have this.

If you only remember one thing

Riley's strengths are not the consolation prize after the diagnosis list. They are the operating system. The new rhythmic breathing sound he's invented is the most exciting milestone in this report — protect it.

SECTION 05 · COMMUNICATION QUICK GUIDE

How to Talk With Riley

Verbal — but his words evaporate when he's stretched. Adjust the volume of your face and tone, not the volume of your voice. This is the section to copy, paste, and hand to anyone new in his life.

Phrases that work — and ones to retire

SAY THIS ✓	INSTEAD OF ✗
"Pause." / "Wait." / "Hold on."	"STOP."
"I'm not going to feed that thought or worry."	"That's silly" / "That's not real"
"I see you. Take a deep breath with me."	"Calm down."
"Here's what I think." (one calm opinion)	"Because I said so."
"Red is the color of fire trucks." (neutral)	"Red is bad / Green is good."
"Want a hug?" (offer; don't make him earn)	"Use your words."
"Let's get back to the present moment."	"What were you just thinking about?"
"That was hard. You bounced back. I'm proud of you."	"You're fine, it's not a big deal."

Five rules for any conversation that matters

1. Calm tone first, words second. Riley hears your face before he hears your sentence. If you're frustrated, regulate yourself before speaking — every time.

2. Get to his eye level. Crouch, sit on the floor. Physical-height parity is grounding.

3. Don't engage stuck thoughts. When he loops on a comparison or trick question, don't argue or explain. Use the script: "I'm not going to feed that thought."

4. Offer hugs liberally. Hugs are not a reward. They are a regulating tool. Every request honored, plus extras when transitions are hard.

5. Repair quietly, hours later. Recovery is fast (30 min – few hours), but post-incident discussion can't happen until well after — sometimes the next day. Wait for him to come to it.

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SECTION 06 · REGULATION TOOLKIT

Tools, in the Order to Try Them

Numbered tiers from **1** (regulated and well) to **4** (full meltdown / shutdown). Each tier has its own color shading and its own job. The point is to use tier-1 and tier-2 tools *before* the nervous system escalates — not to wait until tier 4 and reach for the biggest hammer.

TIER	WHAT'S HAPPENING	WHAT TO DO
1 Regulated	Banking minutes. Riley is light, laughing, doing his work, sitting with a pile of books.	Co-regulate. Stack the day with predictable rhythm. Music. Cats. Cheerios in the car. A walk before lunch. Lunch at 12:00.
2 Stretched	Early signs: verbal looping, repeating phrases, the breathing sound starting up, asking for extra hugs.	Honor the breathing sound (it's working). Offer a hug. Move to a quieter space. Reduce demands for the next 30 min. The Heart Coherence app is available.
3 Escalating	Trick questions to strangers. "Inappropriate" comments to confirm "I'm in trouble." Stuck thought looping in tighter circles.	Get to his eye level. Calm tone, soft volume. "I'm not going to feed that thought or worry." Offer a hug. Don't argue with the thought. Don't show any frustration.
4 Meltdown / shutdown	Biting his arm. Hitting his head (not hard, but hard enough to notice). Speaking very negatively about himself. Embarrassment compounds — especially in public.	Lower your voice. Get close. Hugs welcome if he reaches for one. Quiet, low light, low demand. Plan: bath, book time, no school work for the rest of the session. Recovery 30 min – few hours; affirm the bounce-back when it lands.

SECTION 07 · IMPLEMENTATION FRAMEWORK

Your 12-Week Map

Built around the three goals you named: **(1)** rebuild trust in adults outside the household after the public-school PTSD, **(2)** support social re-entry through interest-anchored low-stakes encounters, **(3)** grow Riley's confidence in his own abilities. Each phase has one primary lever — never more.

Weeks 1–2 · LANGUAGE RESET

The whole household removes "STOP" from active vocabulary. Color-as-moral framing is retired. "I'm not going to feed that thought or worry" becomes the family-wide phrase.

ACTIONS THIS PHASE

- Print the Riley Reference Card and post it on the fridge.
- Family meeting — including extended family who visit — to agree on the language reset.
- Replace "STOP" with: pause / wait / hold on / freeze / hands down. Use a quarter jar if it helps.
- Mom + Dad practice the frustrated-face check: 'Am I showing it?' before speaking.
- Daily: honor every hug request without commentary.

WHAT TO EXPECT

- Lots of accidental "STOP"s in the first week. Self-correct calmly and move on.
- Riley may notice the change and comment on it. That's a good sign — he's tracking the shift.
- Babysitters and visiting family need a 5-min onboarding.

Weeks 3–4 · BUILD TRUST IN ADULTS OUTSIDE THE HOUSEHOLD

Riley's PTSD recovery centers here. Lay groundwork for re-trust with the providers and instructors he sees regularly.

ACTIONS THIS PHASE

- Identify the 3 adults Riley already trusts most (likely Mom, Brooke, Mr. Pezzillo) and explicitly name them as "Riley's team" out loud.
- Brief each new provider Riley is meeting on the "honor the lean" rule. Share the Riley Reference Card.
- Add no new adults during this phase. Stability over breadth.
- End each provider visit with explicit, specific praise: "You walked in. You sat down. You did one thing."

WHAT TO EXPECT

- Riley may have elevated behaviors at the start of any new session. That's expected. The lean is the win.
- Trust takes weeks, not days. Resist 'how was it?' questions right after sessions.

Weeks 5–6 · SOFTEN THE RIGIDITY LOOP

Begin the slow work of helping Riley hold ambiguity. Not challenging the synesthesia or the categorical thinking — introducing 'AND' alongside 'OR' as a frame.

ACTIONS THIS PHASE

- Add the daily phrase: "Two things can be true at once."
- When a stuck thought arrives, don't argue. Try: "Tell me more about that — and what's happening in your body right now?" — pivots to interoception.
- Re-introduce the Heart Coherence app at 1 scheduled time/day (not just during storms).
- Notice and name when he uses the breathing sound — quietly, to yourself, not as commentary to him.

WHAT TO EXPECT

- Stuck thoughts may still happen daily; that's not failure.
- First wins are tiny: a 5-second pause longer than usual; a thought that drops without escalation.

Weeks 7–8 · SOCIAL RE-ENTRY — INTEREST-ANCHORED

Begin his social goal — friendships — through his existing structured groups (Speaking of Social, Autism Project social group, Special Olympics, soccer). NOT through new informal contexts.

ACTIONS THIS PHASE

- Pre-brief Riley before each social-group session: who, what, how long, what we'll do after.
- Use his special interests as conversation on-ramps with other kids: trains, fonts, animals, music.
- Post-session: 5-minute "what did you notice about yourself?" (NOT "did you make a friend?").
- If a peer relationship starts to form, support it carefully: short, structured first hangouts.

WHAT TO EXPECT

- Riley may report that group was "fine" without elaboration. That's data — fine = he didn't dysregulate.
- Friendship development is slow for autistic kids — months not weeks. Hold the long view.

Weeks 9–10 · CONFIDENCE — NAME WHAT HE CAN DO

Build Goal 3: confidence in his own abilities. Specific praise anchored in his interests and his recovery wins.

ACTIONS THIS PHASE

- Daily: name one specific thing he did. "You came back to the present in 2 minutes today. That's faster than last week."
- Make him the expert on something he loves. Have him teach you about a font, a train line, a cat behavior.
- Photo or note in a 'Riley did this' visible spot — fridge, bulletin board.
- When the breathing sound shows up, internally celebrate. Don't comment to him.

WHAT TO EXPECT

- He may shrug off praise. The point isn't acknowledgment — it's the consistent input.
- Building a sense of self after PTSD is rebuilding, not revealing. Have patience.

Weeks 11–12 · GENERALIZE AND REVIEW

Bring Sam, the babysitters, and the extended family fully into the practice. Review what landed.

ACTIONS THIS PHASE

- Print updated copies of the Reference Card for: Sam, Emily (neighbor), Erika, the babysitters, and Brooke at the Autism Project.
- 20-minute Mom + Dad review: what's noticeably better? What's still hard? Where's Sam at?
- Schedule a 20-minute call with Brooke and Ms. Denise to align home and clinic.
- Formally validate to Sam the work she's been doing — without making her the topic.

WHAT TO EXPECT

- This is the first plateau where things feel sustainable, not heroic. Hard days happen but no longer derail the week.
- Riley's confidence shows up in small ways — fewer trick questions, more direct asks, more lean-toward-trust moments.

SECTION 08 · CRISIS DE-ESCALATION

The Playbook for the Hardest 90 Minutes

Once a meltdown is underway, your job changes from teacher to lifeguard. Riley's nervous system reads your face before your words. Connection over correction. Recovery before repair.

00:00 · Regulate your own face first

Riley's nervous system locks onto your expression before he hears your words. Drop your shoulders, soften your forehead, lower your voice BEFORE you say anything.

00:01 · Get to his eye level

Crouch, sit on the floor, kneel. Physical height parity is grounding. Stay within 3 feet but don't crowd.

00:03 · Offer a hug

"Want a hug?" If yes, hug long and firm. If no, don't push. Hugs are HIS regulator, not yours to enforce.

00:05 · One sentence, then silence

"I see you." OR "I'm not going to feed that thought or worry." One only. Then stop talking. Let the breathing sound show up if it wants to.

00:10 · Reduce sensory + demand load

Quieter room. Lights softer. Cats nearby if possible. Drop every demand from the next 30 min. School work pauses without consequence.

00:30 – few hours · The recovery

Bath. Book time. Music if he wants it. The Heart Coherence app is on the table. No questions, no debrief. He'll come back.

Hours later · Repair

Once he's fully back: "That was hard. You bounced back. I'm proud of you. I love you." That's all. The post-mortem can happen the next day if at all.

Important — escalating self-harm

If self-harm intensifies (biting harder, hitting harder), or if you become concerned about safety, call your pediatrician (your pediatrician), Riley's Autism Project team, or — for a true crisis — the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. This report is informational, not crisis intervention.

SECTION 09 · TRIGGER WORD REPLACEMENTS

The Specific Word Swaps for Riley

These are the live, named substitutions for Riley — most importantly, **STOP**, his current biggest trigger word. Every adult he sees, including extended family and visiting friends, needs the swap list.

RETIRE	USE INSTEAD	WHY
"STOP"	"Pause / Wait / Hold on / Freeze"	STOP is Riley's live trigger word. It pulls him back into the PTSD body memory. Replace it everywhere — every adult, every context, every visitor.
"Red is bad / Green is good"	"Red is the color of fire trucks"	Riley's synesthesia means colors have feelings. Moralizing a color tells him it has bad feelings, which distresses him.
"Calm down"	"Take a breath with me"	Calm cannot be commanded. Co-regulating models it.
"Because I said so"	"Here's what I think..."	Authority-only reasoning collapses Riley into the adult-emotional-state focus he can't hear past.
"That's not real" / "That's silly"	"I'm not going to feed that thought or worry."	Don't dismiss the synesthetic / categorical thoughts. Don't engage them either. Acknowledge without confirming.
"Use your words"	"Want a hug?" or eye-level silence	When he's stretched, words go offline. Demands for words compound the dysregulation.
"You're fine"	"That was hard. You bounced back."	Don't minimize. Affirm the difficulty AND the recovery.

SECTION 10 · DAILY RHYTHM PROTOCOL

Riley's Day, Held Lightly

Riley's good days have a recognizable shape — Mom described it in detail. This protocol holds that shape sacred while leaving room for repair when the day asks for it.

Drop-off run · 7:30–8:30 a.m.

- Cheerios in the car for Riley on the drive to drop Sam at school.
- Lyric-free or favorite music in the car — his choice.
- Same route every time. No surprise stops. No new errands appended without warning.
- On return: a quiet 5-minute window before getting dressed. He can pet a cat or look at a book.

Morning work · 9:00–11:30 a.m.

- Real breakfast first; he may bring a book to the table.
- Schoolwork in 20–25 min blocks with movement breaks.
- When stuck thoughts arrive, deploy: "I'm not going to feed that thought or worry." Then redirect to the work or to a walk.
- Honor every hug request — it does NOT pause the work. Hug, then continue.

Lunch · exactly 12:00 — non-negotiable

- 12:00 is Riley's anchor. Don't drift it.
- Quiet music or audiobook during lunch is fine.
- Brief outdoor time after if weather allows.

Afternoon · 1:00–3:30 p.m.

- Walk, then more work, then karate for Sam (Riley rides along).
- If Riley's day is becoming hard, drop the second work block. The day doesn't need to fit the plan — the plan needs to fit the day.
- Books, music, painting — these are repair tools, not rewards.

Evening · bath / books / bed

- Bath is regulating, especially after a hard day.
- Bedtime: pajamas, brush teeth, wipe face. Tell him each step ONCE.
- Both bathroom lights stay on. Salt lamp on. Other lights off.
- He may not fall asleep until Mom is home — that's currently his pattern. Honor it without making it the goal to break.

SECTION 11 · WEEK ONE CHECKLIST

Five Things to Do This Week

Concrete steps for the next 7 days. Start with #1 — everything else builds on it.

■	Print the Riley Reference Card and put it on the fridge. Email a copy to Sam, Emily (neighbor), and Erika.	Tonight
■	Family-wide "STOP" retirement. Replace with pause / wait. If anyone slips, calm correction, no shame.	Starting tomorrow
■	Honor every hug request — without commentary. Track it for a week and notice your own reaction.	Daily
■	Practice the script: "I'm not going to feed that thought or worry." Use it once a day on a low-stakes thought first.	Daily
■	Schedule the 20-minute call with Brooke (Autism Project) and Ms. Denise (Speaking of Social) to align home + clinic.	This week

Permission to be slow

If you do **only one** of these this week, do #1. The fridge card is the foundation. Everything else rests on top.

SECTION 12 · PROGRESS TRACKING

How to Know It's Working

Track trends over weeks, not perfection day-to-day. Riley is already 'bouncing back' faster — celebrate that as the leading indicator.

Micro-wins worth celebrating

- Recovery time after a hard moment shortened by even 5 minutes.
- Riley used his rhythmic breathing sound during a stretched moment (NOT a meltdown).
- He asked for a hug instead of biting his arm, even once.
- He dropped a stuck thought without it spiraling.
- He came back to the present moment when grounded — without an argument first.
- A new adult got a lean from him within the first 3 sessions.
- Sam handled a hard moment without becoming dysregulated herself.
- The household went a full day with no "STOP" said by anyone.

If progress stalls

If after 6 weeks you don't see movement, verify three things FIRST: is everyone using the language reset (no STOP, no color-as-moral)? Is every hug request being honored? Is at least one calm-tone adult check happening before each interaction? If yes to all three and still no progress, schedule a 20-minute alignment call with the family's behavioral provider.

SECTION 13 · RILEY'S EXISTING TEAM

The People Already in Riley's Circle

You named a strong existing team. This section is the alignment map — what each person should know, and what to ask them at the next check-in.

The Autism Project · Brooke (Mon & Thu)

Likely his strongest current trust relationship outside family. Reinforce by: aligning home language with what Brooke uses; monthly 20-min check-in with Mom to align goals.

QUESTIONS TO ASK AT NEXT CHECK-IN

- *Are there 1-2 specific phrases Brooke uses that we should mirror at home?*
- *Where is he in the work? What's plateauing? What's progressing?*

Speaking of Social · Ms. Denise (every other Tuesday)

Social-skills group is the entry point for Goal 2 (friendships). Pre-briefs and post-debriefs are the work.

QUESTIONS TO ASK AT NEXT CHECK-IN

- *Which kids in the group might be a safe peer match?*
- *What's Ms. Denise observing socially — strengths and gaps?*

Karate · Mr. Pezzillo (Fridays)

A reliable shape of Riley's week. Movement + structure + a trusted male instructor who sees him regularly.

QUESTIONS TO ASK AT NEXT CHECK-IN

- *Has Mr. Pezzillo noticed shifts in Riley's confidence?*
- *Are there moments in karate that are particularly regulating?*

Special Olympics + Unified Soccer · Declan and Emily

Low-stakes peer environment. Win condition is participation, not performance.

QUESTIONS TO ASK AT NEXT CHECK-IN

- *Where does he engage most? Where does he hold back?*

Babysitters · Emily and Gianna (2x/week)

These are the day-in / day-out trusted others. They need the Reference Card AND a 30-min walk-through.

QUESTIONS TO ASK AT NEXT CHECK-IN

- *What patterns are Emily and Gianna noticing? Anything new?*

SECTION 14 · ADDITIONAL REFERRALS TO CONSIDER

Specialists Worth Looping In

Two areas surfaced from the questionnaire that could use a specialist beyond the existing team — both are about supporting Riley through the current moment specifically.

Pediatric mental health (PTSD-trained)

Riley has named PTSD from public school. A clinician trained in trauma-informed care for autistic kids — not just generic CBT — can address the rigidity loop and the social-anxiety component. Ask about EMDR adaptations for autism, or trauma-informed play / art therapy.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- *Do you specifically work with autistic children with PTSD?*
- *How do you adapt for synesthetic experience and rigid thinking?*
- *Do you involve the family in the work?*

Pediatrician + puberty conversation

Riley is hitting puberty. Mom flagged that emotional intensity can produce involuntary physiological responses Riley doesn't yet have language for. The pediatrician should be looped in for developmentally-appropriate, autism-aware puberty support.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- *Are there autism-affirming puberty resources you'd recommend?*
- *When is the right time for a developmental check-in?*
- *Any concerns about the sleep regression / night fears?*

REFERENCE GUIDE

Riley · Age 12 · Autism + PTSD + Synesthesia

Keep visible — fridge /
car / bag

WHO HE IS

Riley is a verbal, exceptionally bright 12-year-old. Curious, fun-loving, deep memory, loves music / books / fonts / trains / animals / his cats Pepper and Olive. Lives between two homes — Mom's (primary regulator, cats here, comes in to her at night) and Dad's. PTSD from public school is live. "STOP" is his biggest trigger word.

HIS STRENGTHS

- Cinematic memory + fact recall
- Loves music of every kind
- Painting, animals, his cats
- Wants to make people proud
- Uses a self-invented breathing sound to regulate

WORDS / TONES TO RETIRE

"STOP" — biggest trigger word, retire entirely
"Red is bad / Green is good" — synesthesia distress
"Because I said so"
Any visible frustration or anger on your face
Force eye contact or "use your words"

WHAT HELPS HIM

Calm tone first, words second

- Get to his eye level
- Hugs — honor every request
- Music (lyric-free in car, anything else fine)
- Phrase: "I'm not going to feed that thought or worry"
- Books, walks, the Heart Coherence app

EXACT PHRASES TO USE

Stuck thought / trick question:

"I'm not going to feed that thought or worry."

Early dysregulation:

"I see you. Take a breath with me."

Asking him to pause:

"Pause / Wait / Hold on." (Never STOP.)

Mid-meltdown (one sentence):

"I see you." Then silence. Offer a hug.

After he comes back:

"That was hard. You bounced back. I am proud of you."

With a new adult:

"He may need a few sessions before he leans toward you."

IF THINGS ESCALATE — IN ORDER

- 1 Regulate your face first.** Drop shoulders. Soften forehead. Lower voice.
- 2 Get to his eye level.** Crouch / sit. Stay within 3 feet, don't crowd.
- 3 Offer a hug.** If yes, hug long and firm. If no, don't push.
- 4 One sentence + recovery.** "I see you." Then: bath, books, low demand. 30 min – few hours.

APPENDIX · THE CONVERSATION BEHIND THIS PLAN

Every Question You Were Asked — and Your Answers

Verbatim. Intentionally formatted to be handed to a new doctor, therapist, school team, or specialist — so you never have to retell Riley's story from scratch again.

Section A · Foundational questions

Q. Child's first name

A. Riley

Q. Last initial

A. M.

Q. Age

A. 12

Q. Pronouns

A. he/him

Q. Grade level

A. 6th grade (homeschooled, with active IEP)

Q. Primary diagnosis or diagnoses

A. Autism Spectrum Disorder; PTSD (school-related); Synesthesia — object-personality (he experiences objects, colors, and words as having moral and emotional valence)

Q. Your role

A. Parent (Mother)

Q. Biggest challenge right now

A. Riley has a fixation on thinking everyone is mad at him. He'll ask what we call 'trick questions' that lead the other person to the wrong answer, and he gets upset or struggles with the responses. He is a very literal black-and-white thinker, and he experiences objects as having feelings — for example, he believes the color red gets upset when it's used for inappropriate things. His fixations and rigidity of thought make social situations stressful. He almost antagonizes others verbally with his thoughts and then becomes upset thinking they're upset with him. I really want him to feel more comfortable and natural in social settings.

Q. Primary communication style

A. Verbal (does not use AAC)

Q. Frequency of meltdowns / shutdowns

A. Weekly

Q. Sensory areas of significant sensitivity

A. Sound (specifically the energetic complexity of crowded spaces — loud music in the car is fine, but a busy room is overwhelming); Smell (sensitive nose; the burnt-toast smell of breakfast diners is hard)

Q. Current school setting

A. Homeschool (public-school PTSD is part of why we left)

Section B · Comprehensive questions**Q. Describe Riley's strengths**

A. Riley has an incredible memory. He loves animals deeply, paints, and is constantly learning and studying random facts and images. He loves music of every kind. And he loves making people proud of him — this is one of the most beautiful things about him.

Q. Riley's special interests

A. Books. Fonts. Trains. Days of the week and years. His cats, Pepper and Olive. Music.

Q. Top 3 current goals for Riley

A. 1. Help him trust external environments and teachers/instructors again — we're still working through PTSD from public school. 2. Help him become more comfortable in social settings so he can develop friendships. 3. Build more confidence in his own abilities.

Q. Sleep patterns

A. Some difficulty. Riley has recently become scared at night and wants to sleep with Mom every night at her house. He says he gets scared at Dad's too, but doesn't go in with him the way he does with Mom.

Q. Eating

A. No issues. Wide range of safe foods.

Q. Social skills

A. Prefers to be alone. Social anxiety + PTSD make group settings and unfamiliar adults feel unsafe.

Q. Emotional regulation tools that currently help

A. Deep pressure (especially hugs — he asks for them many times a day even when he isn't visibly upset); movement breaks; quiet space; music and audiobooks; co-regulation with a parent (especially Mom). Recently he has begun making a rhythmic breathing sound that appears to be a self-regulation attempt.

Q. School support plan

A. IEP (active)

Q. Does Riley have siblings?

A. Yes — Sam, age 14

Q. Sibling profile

A. Sam, 14 — likes karate, reading, being outside. Doesn't like mornings or being embarrassed in public. On hard days she tries to help Mom and Dad, but also sometimes acts like another parent (out of loving protection) for Riley. Her closest outside-family friend is Alex.

Q. How are siblings affected on hard days?

A. Sam gets embarrassed if it happens in public. She's frustrated when plans have to change or be shortened because Riley is having a hard time. If it's a hard day for Mom or Dad, she becomes overly loving and tries to help out more.

Q. A 'good day' for Riley

A. Wakes up happy and not stuck on thoughts from the day before. Cheerios in the car on the way to drop Sam at school. Music in the car. Comes home and gets dressed while real breakfast is made. Some schoolwork. Usually a walk. Lunch is always at 12:00. Then outdoor time, more work, and karate for Sam. On a good day Riley is light and fun, laughs at seemingly nothing, is proud of himself for doing his work, and most often ends the day sitting with a pile of books.

Q. A 'hard day' for Riley

A. Usually starts with a stuck thought. Trying to understand the 'logic' or connection behind his thoughts can be challenging — he often compares two unrelated things, which creates confusion and anxiety on his part. It can escalate from biting his arm to hitting his head (not necessarily hard, but hard enough we can't ignore). He's been better about 'rebounding' from bad days, but the recovery usually has to include a bath to help him calm, book time, and limited school work.

Q. Specific known triggers

A. The word 'STOP' is the biggest trigger word right now. Color associations — green for good, red for bad — also make him very upset because of his synesthetic experience of objects having feelings. When he asks 'trick' questions to people he doesn't really know, he is usually setting the situation up for failure.

Q. Anything else we should know

A. We are also hitting puberty. Watching Riley try to understand his feelings and body changes — and helping him really understand it's okay — is challenging. As his emotions heighten, he can experience erections just from the energy shift, and that is really frustrating for him. His mind is so busy all the time, like ten movies playing all at once. I have to really try to get him back into the present moment a lot.

Q. Final note from Mom

A. Riley is a smart, fun-loving boy. I just feel he really regressed in all manners while in public education. He is improving substantially at home, but I worry about him becoming lonely — though he doesn't really seem to mind being home. He is so much more himself here.

A NOTE FOR YOU

Before you close this report.

If you've made it this far, you have just sat with more information about your child than most professionals will read about Riley in a year. That is a profound act of love. We want to name it before you do anything else with what follows.

This work is exhausting. You cannot pour from an empty cup, and the consistency this plan asks of you depends on you being regulated yourself. Your nervous system directly impacts your child's. So before this report becomes another to-do list, please read this page.

- Choosing to seek understanding instead of compliance was the right call.
- Riley **is** already changing — you just can't always see the rewiring while it's happening.
- Three years of pattern cannot be unlearned in three weeks. Your timeline is allowed to be long.
- Every regulation tool you offer — even the ones that don't seem to land — is teaching the nervous system that home is safe.
- You are not behind. You are not failing. You are doing the hardest, quietest, most important work there is.

Your non-negotiables.

Identify one person who can give you a 2-hour break each week. Take 10 minutes a day that is just yours — not negotiable. Consider therapy or counseling for yourself; vicarious trauma is real, and watching your child struggle leaves marks on your own nervous system. Find one community of parents walking the same road. You are not the only one.

If today is a hard day

Re-read just one anchor truth above. Drink a glass of water. Step outside for 60 seconds. Do not implement another section of this report tonight. Tomorrow is fine. You are doing this right.

You are seen. You are not alone. You are doing it.

— Sarah, founder of Pieces of Perception, & Proud Mama

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